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Tesla partly liable in Florida Autopilot trial, jury awards \$200M in damages



A jury in federal court in Miami has found Tesla partly to blame for a fatal 2019 crash that involved the use of the company's Autopilot driver assistance system.

The jury assessed punitive damages only against Tesla, [CNBC reported](#). The punitive fines coupled with a compensatory damages puts the total payments to around \$242.5 million. The plaintiff's attorney confirmed to TechCrunch that this is the correct amount.

Neither the driver of the car nor the Autopilot system braked in time to avoid going through an intersection, where the car struck an SUV and killed a pedestrian. The jury assigned the driver two-thirds of the blame, and attributed one-third to Tesla. (The driver was sued separately.)

The verdict comes at the end of a three-week trial over the crash, which killed 20-year-old Naibel Benavides Leon and severely injured her boyfriend Dillon Angulo. The verdict is one of the first major legal decisions about driver assistance technology that has gone against Tesla. The company has previously settled lawsuits [involving similar claims about Autopilot](#).

Brett Schreiber, the lead attorney for the plaintiffs in the case, said in a statement to TechCrunch that Tesla designed Autopilot "only for controlled access highways yet deliberately chose not to restrict

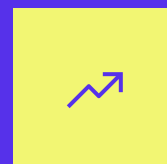
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drivers from using it elsewhere, alongside Elon Musk telling the world Autopilot drove better than humans.”

“Tesla’s lies turned our roads into test tracks for their fundamentally flawed technology, putting everyday Americans like Naibel Benavides and Dillon Angulo in harm’s way,” said Schreiber. “Today’s verdict represents justice for Naibel’s tragic death and Dillon’s lifelong injuries, holding Tesla and Musk accountable for propping up the company’s trillion-dollar valuation with self-driving hype at the expense of human lives.”

Tesla, in a statement provided to TechCrunch, said it plans to appeal the verdict “given the substantial errors of law and irregularities at trial.”

“Today’s verdict is wrong and only works to set back automotive safety and jeopardize Tesla’s and the entire industry’s efforts to develop and implement life-saving technology,” the company wrote. “To be clear, no car in 2019, and none today, would have prevented this crash. This was never about Autopilot; it was a fiction concocted by plaintiffs’ lawyers blaming the car when the driver — from day one — admitted and accepted responsibility.”

Tesla and Musk spent years making claims about Autopilot’s capabilities that have led to overconfidence in the driver assistance system, a reality that government officials — and Musk himself — have spoken about for years.

The National Transportation Safety Board (NTSB) came to this determination in 2020 after investigating a 2018 crash where the driver died after hitting a concrete barrier. That driver, Walter Huang, was [playing a mobile game while using Autopilot](#). The NTSB made a number of recommendations following that investigation,

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which [Tesla largely ignored](#), the [safety board later claimed](#).

On a 2018 conference call, Musk said “complacency” with driver assistance systems like Autopilot is a problem.

“They just get too used to it. That tends to be more of an issue. It’s not a lack of understanding of what Autopilot can do. It’s [drivers] thinking they know more about Autopilot than they do,” Musk [said at the time](#).

The trial took place at a time when Tesla is currently in the [middle of rolling out the first versions of its long-promised Robotaxi network](#), starting in Austin, Texas. Those vehicles are using an enhanced version of Tesla’s more capable driver assistance system, which it calls Full Self-Driving.

Update: This story has been updated to include the amount of compensatory damages in the total.

Topics: [advanced driver assistance systems](#) [Autopilot](#)

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IMAGE CREDITS: JOBY

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Joby Aviation to buy Blade Air Mobility's ride-share business

Kirsten Korosec — 4:18 AM PDT · August 4, 2025

Electric air taxi developer Joby Aviation has agreed to buy Blade Air Mobility's helicopter ride-share business for as much as \$125 million.

Joby is buying the Blade brand and the company's passenger business, which includes operations in the United States and Europe. Blade founder and CEO Rob Wiesenthal will continue to lead the business, which will operate as a wholly-owned subsidiary of Joby.

Blade's medical division, which transports organs, isn't included in the transaction and will remain a separate company.

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The deal gives Joby instant access to a network of 12 terminals in key markets like New York City — notably, a dedicated lounge as well as terminal bases at John F. Kennedy International Airport, Newark Liberty Airport, the West Side of Manhattan, the East Side of Manhattan, and Wall Street.

Blade, founded in 2014, doesn’t own a fleet of aircraft. Instead, the company has developed a digital network that allows passengers to book private rides on helicopters across several short-hop routes. The service has grown in popularity as well-heeled customers seek out ways to avoid traffic on their commutes from the suburbs into Manhattan, or to The Hamptons for weekends and holidays. The company, which also offers access to routes from Nice, France, to Monaco and Saint-Tropez, flew more than 50,000 passengers in 2024.

Joby Aviation founder and CEO JoeBen Bevirt described the deal as a “strategically important” acquisition that will support its launch of its commercial operations in Dubai and subsequent global rollout. The company said it will integrate its software, which is designed to manage air taxi operations, into Blade’s passenger service.

Joby, founded in 2009 by Bevirt, has been working for more than a decade to develop, certify and produce an electric vertical take off and landing (eVTOL) aircraft for commercial taxi service in cities. (The company is also pursuing a separate [defense-related business](#).) Eventually, the branded Blade service will use electric air taxis, not helicopters in its service, according to the companies.

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Toyota-backed Joby [went public](#) in 2021 through a merger with Reinvent Technology Partners, a special purpose acquisition company backed by LinkedIn co-founder Reid Hoffman and Zynga founder Mark Pincus.

Under terms of the agreement, Joby is holding back \$35 million of the purchase price, which will be released if Blade hits certain performance milestones and retains certain key employees.

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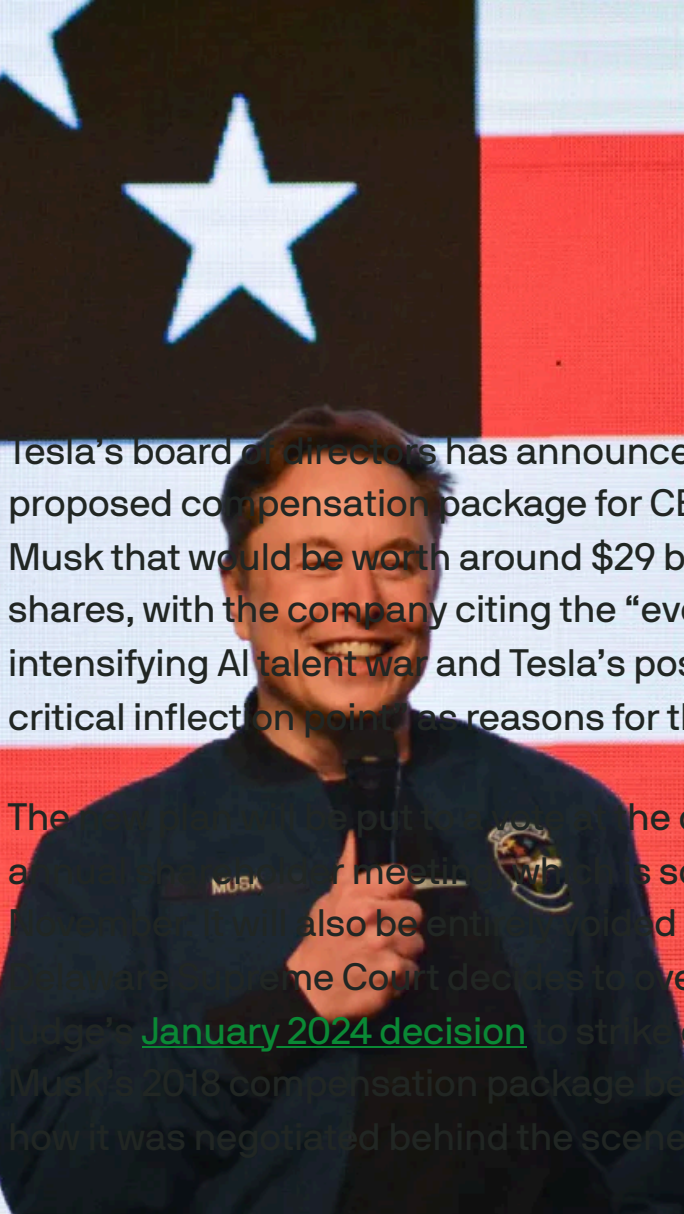
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Tesla asks shareholders to approve \$29B comp package for Elon Musk amid ‘AI talent war’



Tesla's board of directors has announced a proposed compensation package for CEO Elon Musk that would be worth around \$29 billion in shares, with the company citing the “ever-intensifying AI talent war and Tesla's position at a critical inflection point” as reasons for the payout.

The new plan will be put to a vote at the company's annual shareholder meeting, which is scheduled for November. It will also be entirely voided if the Delaware Supreme Court decides to overturn a judge's [January 2024 decision](#) to strike down Musk's 2018 compensation package because of how it was negotiated behind the scenes.

Musk has threatened to stop working on AI and robotics at Tesla [unless he gains more control over the company](#). Those threats preceded what is now a multi-million dollar talent war among the [biggest companies in the artificial intelligence space](#), along with a rush of mergers and acquisitions. Musk has simultaneously built up his own AI company outside Tesla called xAI, which now owns X, his social media platform.

Tesla [said](#) Monday that its board of directors formed a special committee earlier this year consisting of chairwoman Robyn Denholm and board member Kathleen Wilson-Thompson in order to sort out a new package.

The award they ultimately decided on involves giving Musk 96 million shares that will vest in two years, provided that he “serve continuously in a

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senior leadership role at Tesla” during that term and holds the stock for five years. Unlike Tesla’s previous award to Musk, this new package does not appear to be tied to goals like increasing the company’s stock price.

At Tesla’s Monday pre-market trading price, that would be worth around \$29 billion. Musk will have to pay a \$23.34-per-share purchase price, bringing the total current value of the award to him to roughly \$26.7 billion. Depending on how the Delaware Supreme Court rules on Tesla’s appeal, the package may be forfeited so “there cannot be any ‘double dip,’ according to Tesla.

“Elon will not be able to keep this new award in addition to the options he will be awarded under the 2018 CEO Performance Award should the courts rule in our favor,” the company wrote.

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Tesla said Musk and his brother Kimbal, who is also a board member, recused themselves from the process of constructing this new compensation package. Musk’s involvement in the 2018 compensation package, which was worth around \$56 billion, was one of the reasons why Delaware Chancery Court judge chancellor Kathaleen McCormick [decided to strike it down](#) following a trial sparked by a shareholder lawsuit.

McCormick said the process of creating that 2018 plan was “deeply flawed” because of Musk’s input and his deep connections to the people on Tesla’s board. She also criticized that plan for not including any terms that would bind Musk to Tesla for “any set amount of time” — a likely reason for the two-year pledge included in the new plan.

McCormick’s decision caused an uproar among Tesla’s largest fans and many of its shareholders. It’s also what inspired the company to re-incorporate from Delaware to Texas, a state with fewer established shareholder protections written into its laws. Tesla went as far as holding a shareholder vote to “re-affirm” the pay package. But McCormick [confirmed her decision in December 2024](#), saying the vote and Tesla’s legal arguments were “unprecedented theories [that] go against multiple strains of settled law.”

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Joby Aviation and defense contractor L3Harris to test autonomous hybrid aircraft

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Joby Aviation is often cast as a developer of commercial electric air taxis, but the publicly traded company has also pursued a separate track to market through a long-standing relationship with the U.S. Department of Defense. Now, its years of research and development with the Department of Defense may be paying off.

The company on Thursday said it had signed an agreement with defense contractor L3Harris Technologies to “explore opportunities” to develop a new aircraft class — specifically, a gas-turbine hybrid vertical take-off and landing aircraft that can fly autonomously — for defense applications.

The gas-turbine hybrid VTOL will be based on Joby’s current S4 aircraft platform. The company has focused on developing the S4 with an all-electric powertrain, but it last year demonstrated under government contract a [hydrogen-electric hybrid version](#) that flew 521 miles — more than two times farther than its battery electric prototype.

The agreement with L3Harris is exploratory, but the hope is that upcoming flight tests and operational demonstrations will lead to a military contract with the DoD. Joby said flight testing will start this fall, and operational demonstrations are expected in 2026.

Joby has spent years developing and seeking Type 1 certification from the Federal Aviation Administration for its all-electric vertical take-off

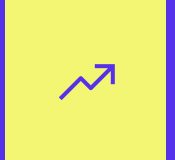
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and landing aircraft, which will be used to shuttle passengers short distances in urban areas.

It's also worked with the DoD at the development stage for nearly a decade. Through that relationship, Joby homed in on what it would take to get to the "finish line" with the DoD, Joby executive chairman Paul Sciarra told TechCrunch.

"One of that range was especially important," he said. "We knew we had to make that shift."

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Sciarra added it was also important to demonstrate the so-called “missionization of its platform” — how its aircraft could be combined with the right sensors, autonomy, communications and payload to provide a clear use case for the DoD.

“We have two choices: either build a bunch of this stuff ourselves, or find an incredible partner that already has a deep understanding of those use cases and a ton of proven technology,” he said.

That’s where L3Harris comes in.

Jon Rambeau, president of Integrated Mission Systems at L3Harris, said the new vertical lift technology will enable long-range, crewed-uncrewed teaming for a range of missions. In this case, the gas-turbine hybrid VTOL aircraft could be used for low-altitude support missions, which could include contested logistics, electronic warfare, and counter unmanned aircraft systems, or C-UAS, Sciarra said.

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Transportation Editor |

Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

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Ford to reveal more about its new low-cost electric vehicles on August 11

Sean O'Kane — 7:14 AM PDT · July 31, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:

JAKUB PORZYCKI / GETTY IMAGES

Ford is set to reveal more information about its upcoming low-cost electric vehicles at an event in Kentucky on August 11. And the company is talking a very big game: CEO Jim Farley [said](#) Wednesday that the announcement is “a Model T moment” for Ford.

Farley made the comments after Ford revealed its electric vehicle division posted a loss of around \$1.3 billion in the second quarter of 2025. Sales of the company’s top two EVs, the F-150 Lightning and the Mustang Mach-E, are declining, all while things are looking increasingly tough for electric vehicles under the second Trump administration.

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Farley first revealed that Ford had a skunkworks team developing a low-cost electric vehicle in February 2024. As TechCrunch first reported, the effort is being led by [former Tesla executive Alan Clarke](#), and the team is [brimming with talent](#) from companies like Tesla, Rivian, Apple, and Lucid Motors.

The company has been deliberately vague about any specifics, but has admitted that the first vehicle to be built on this new low-cost platform [will be a mid-size pickup truck](#) set for release in 2027. Ford has said it will build “multiple vehicle styles — for both retail and commercial customers” on the platform, and that these vehicles will feature “personalized digital experiences.”

Cheaper models could help Ford, but 2027 is still a long way out.

While there are basically no mass-market electric vehicles available in the U.S. at or under \$30,000, that likely won't be the case when Ford's secretive EVs hit the market in two years. Tesla has said it will start selling a stripped-down (and possibly smaller) Model Y SUV later this year. General Motors is [bringing back the Chevy Bolt next year](#). And Jeff Bezos-backed startup Slate Auto is putting its own [low-cost electric pickup on sale as early as late 2026](#).

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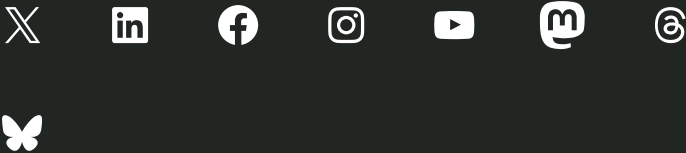
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